

FOLLOWING THE LEAD Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel with PM Modi and home minister Amit Shah at a co-op conclave in Gandhinagar, May 28

NOTHING GOES UNNOTICED in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Gujarat—he likes to keep an eagle eye on affairs in his home state. On May 23, in an unprecedented move, the prime minister's office (PMO) initiated stringent action against two senior officials in the Gujarat government. In the morning, the CBI (Central Bureau of Investigation) arrested flamboyant IAS officer K. Rajesh, joint secretary with the general administration department, on charges of corruption. Barely had the dust settled over the arrest than the chief minister's office, Swarnim Sankul, received another order from the PMO in the late afternoon. This time, the axe fell on Dhrumil Patel, the highly influential personal assistant of Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, for his alleged involvement in a cash-for-postings scandal.

It is perhaps for the first time that such senior officers were being publicly hung out to dry in the state. Dhrumil was the first appointment after Bhupendra Patel took over as CM on September 12, 2021. A seasoned lieutenant of Anandiben Patel , the CM's mentor and the current governor of Uttar Pradesh, he had been despatched to Gandhinagar to assist the 'inexperienced' Patel.

Sources say the PMO was sending a message to the state bureaucracy, and perhaps to the new CM too. In a subtle manner, Modi was also announcing that he has taken over the reins in Gujarat six months ahead of the assembly election. "Bhupendrabhai's nature is *mrudu* (soft), but his decisions are *makkam* (firm)," Modi had said in Gandhinagar in late April. By May 28, the PM was losing his patience and expressing his displeasure openly with Patel's style of functioning. At the inauguration of the Matushri K.D.P. Multispeciality Hospital at Atkot in Rajkot, Modi was seen looking the other way as the CM stood with folded hands before him.

When Patel was chosen as a replacement for Vijay Rupani in September 2021, it was seen as a bid to quell the unrest among the BJP cadre, say sources, as they felt "neglected at the government level". The first-time MLA from Ghatlodia, Ahmedabad, Bhupendra Patel, 59, was also seen as the BJP brass's solution to the strong anti-incumbency building up in the state. In an unheard of move, Patel also got an entirely new council of ministers, all of them—barring Rajendra Trivedi and Kanubhai Desai—newbies and with no experience of running the state.

Eight months on, the party workers, at least, seem mollified. The new CM holds an open house for visitors without appointment twice a week. On May 24, when INDIA TODAY visited, Patel's third-floor office was crowded with close to 500 people waiting to meet him. There were people from all walks of life—common citizens, politicians, businessmen and even aspiring legislators. Most of the cases seemed to revolve around requests to resolve land disputes. A group from Rajasthan wanted the CM's assistance to run their cow shelter in Gujarat. Patel took their memorandums one by one, made some remarks on the paper and handed them over to Nimesh Dave, his officer on special duty, for further action.

Bhupendra Patel's chambers seem to be an embodiment of his ideas about the administration. There are small statues of spiritual guru Dada Bhagwan, Swami Vivekanand and